



Combat Mindset

Proposed Way Forward

Defining, developing and assuring the human-performance capability Army requires to remain effective in combat.

HARDER TO KILL

Proposed Warfighter Focus tagline — subject to sponsor endorsement

Reference	ACS 2026
Date	July 2026
Originator	Army Command School
Version	Draft v0.6

Contents

The Model on a Page.....	3
Purpose.....	4
1. The problem.....	4
2. Terminology and definitions — decision sought.....	4
3. What already exists.....	6
4. Proposed programme of work.....	7
5. Governance.....	8
6. Recommendations.....	9
Annex A — Initial capability and product architecture.....	10

The Model on a Page



COMBAT MINDSET — THE WAY FORWARD

Defining, developing and assuring the human-performance capability Army requires to remain effective in combat.

WARFIGHTING IMPERATIVE

REMAIN EFFECTIVE. ACT DECISIVELY.

Army requires individuals, teams and leaders who remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat.



COMBAT MINDSET

Combat-specific expression

▼ enabled by



PERFORMANCE UNDER PRESSURE

Enabling human-performance capability

▼ developed and organised through



ARMY COMBAT MINDSET FRAMEWORK

Organising model

▼ delivered through

Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure.

The individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission.

Performance Under Pressure is the trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to:

- ✓ Prepare for pressure
- ✓ Recover from pressure
- ✓ Maintain performance through pressure

Applicable across combat, command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity.

The Army Combat Mindset Framework is the organising model through which Army defines, develops, integrates and assures the capabilities, products and governance arrangements that enable Combat Mindset.

It organises:

- Doctrinal definitions
- Desired outcomes
- Capability pillars
- Developmental progression
- Products and methods
- Delivery responsibilities
- Governance
- Evidence
- Assurance

CAPABILITY PILLARS



Leadership



Mental skills



Performance cognition



Resilience & recovery



Physical performance



Professional identity & values



Individual & collective exposure to pressure

▼ each product contributes across multiple pillars

TRAINING PRODUCTS AND METHODS

NZALC
Performance
Under Pressure
package

NZDF Psychology
products

COGCON
(Performance cognition)
Developmental product

Scenario &
experiential
training

Physical
conditioning

Structured
reflection &
recovery

Other products
identified in Phase
1 stocktake

Developed across the Prepare – Perform – Recover cycle · Lead Self ▶ Lead Teams ▶ Lead Leaders ▶ Lead Systems

Delivered by approved training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces across Army



GOVERNANCE AND ASSURANCE

- Army Sponsor — strategic sponsorship and policy direction
- COMDT ACS — interim capability integrator
- ACS — framework development and delivery coordination
- HPC — COGCON product steward; performance-cognition adviser
- Layered doctrine, evidence, professional and delivery assurance



PROGRAMME OF WORK — PHASES 0–4

0. Define terms, sponsorship and relationship
1. Stocktake current capabilities, products and evidence
2. Draft the Army Combat Mindset Framework
3. Validate with stakeholders and units
4. Report back — Framework v1.0, November 2026



HARDER TO KILL

Proposed Warfighter Focus tagline — subject to sponsor endorsement

Purpose

This paper responds to COMDT ACS direction of 16 July 2026 for NZ Army Leadership Centre (NZALC) and the Human Performance Cell (HPC) to jointly develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset doctrine and policy gap. It proposes an agreed problem statement, formal definitions and their relationship for decision, the Army Combat Mindset Framework as the organising model, a programme of work, interim governance and assurance arrangements, and the appropriate nesting of existing training products beneath the framework.

1. The problem

Considerable work on Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure already exists across Army — notably by NZDF Psychology — and elements of it have been endorsed in various settings. What Army does not yet have is a coherent, Army-wide doctrine, governance and assurance model for Combat Mindset, despite the term being in active use and despite Army's drive toward an increased Warfighter Focus. The COMDT ACS guidance reaches the same diagnosis:

Substantial relevant capability already exists across ACS, NZALC, the Human Performance Cell, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and units. The challenge is not primarily a lack of content. It is a lack of visibility, integration, common terminology, strategic ownership and assurance across that existing capability.

The underlying operational problem remains:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

The doctrinal requirement is therefore to define the human-performance capability Army requires, consolidate the substantial body of work that already exists beneath it, and describe its combat-specific expression.

Sufficient evidence and existing capability are available to commence governance, the capability stocktake and framework development immediately. The present gap is not a lack of content; it is a lack of common language, clear ownership and assurance across what already exists.

2. Terminology and definitions — decision sought

One structural decision must be made before the framework can be drafted: the relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure. Two options are offered.

Option 1 — Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure (recommended)

Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure. It describes the individual and collective readiness and disposition Army seeks under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat.

Performance Under Pressure is the enabling human-performance capability: the trainable individual and collective capacity to prepare for, maintain effective performance through and recover from pressure. It is applicable across combat, command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity. Combat Mindset places that broader capability within its specifically warfighting context and connects it to Army's mission, identity, values and operational purpose.

The Army Combat Mindset Framework is the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure the capability pillars, developmental outcomes, training products and governance arrangements that enable this effect.

The following formal definitions are proposed as the drafting baseline.

Combat Mindset. *The combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure: the individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission.*

Performance Under Pressure. *The trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to prepare for, maintain effective performance through and recover from conditions that create significant physiological, cognitive, emotional or social interference.*

Army Combat Mindset Framework. *The organising model through which Army defines, develops, integrates and assures the individual and collective capabilities that enable Combat Mindset.*

Performance Under Pressure describes the trainable human-performance capability. Combat Mindset describes the specifically combat-oriented expression of that capability.

- Gives each term one clear purpose: Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression; Performance Under Pressure is the enabling capability; the Army Combat Mindset Framework is the organising model.
- Keeps Performance Under Pressure applicable wherever significant pressure exists without an enemy; command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity.
- Guards against Combat Mindset being misread as aggression, motivation or resilience alone.
- Harder to Kill remains a proposed Warfighter Focus tagline, subject to sponsor endorsement, and does not form part of the formal definitions.

Option 2 — Combat Mindset as the complete umbrella capability

Combat Mindset is treated as the complete capability itself, integrating leadership, human performance, resilience, mental skills and performance cognition, with performance under pressure expressed within it.

- Maximises simplicity: one term serves as outcome, capability and framework alike.
- Conflates the combat-specific outcome with the broader human-performance capability, reducing applicability outside combat.
- Makes it difficult to distinguish doctrine, capability, framework and product.
- Increases the risk that Combat Mindset is interpreted as motivation or aggression alone.

Both options deliver the end state described in the COMDT ACS guidance. NZALC and HPC jointly recommend Option 1, and will implement whichever option COMDT ACS selects.

3. What already exists

A full stocktake of existing capability and products will be completed during Phase 1. The products described below contribute to the development of Performance Under Pressure and, where applied in a warfighting context, to Combat Mindset. They do not constitute the doctrinal definitions or the complete framework in isolation. Initial holdings include the following.

NZALC Performance Under Pressure package

NZALC delivers a leadership-development approach incorporating Performance = Potential – Interference, Red Head–Blue Head, Prepare–Perform–Recover, mental-skills techniques, psychometrics, experiential activity, feedback and Leadership Development Plans. This material is embedded across Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems.

Human Performance Cell Cognitive Conditioning programme (COGCON)

COGCON is a developmental cognitive-conditioning product designed to train selected dimensions of performance cognition under physical and cognitive load: arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control, working memory, performance monitoring and self-knowledge. Its most mature and potentially scalable component is an adaptive dual-task training module combining a tablet-based cognitive task with a concurrent job-relevant information task, progressive difficulty and performance feedback.

COGCON has demonstrated feasibility, participant acceptability and promising training trends in limited military cohorts. It has not yet been validated as a measure of operational readiness or proven through controlled research to improve real-world military performance. Its current status is therefore that of an emerging, evidence-informed training product rather than an endorsed Army-wide capability system.

NZDF Psychology, ILD and other stakeholders

These organisations hold additional professional expertise, learning products, delivery capability and assurance functions that will be confirmed during the Phase 1 stocktake.

Initial review indicates considerable conceptual alignment across existing products. The Army Combat Mindset Framework will establish a common doctrinal language beneath which individual products and methods can be appropriately nested. It will not require all products to use identical internal methodologies, provided they align to the endorsed framework, outcomes and assurance requirements.

4. Proposed programme of work

Phase 0: Governance and definition (by end July 2026)

Confirm interim sponsorship and capability-integration arrangements, endorse the problem statement, select the terminology option at paragraph 2, and draft for staffing the Army-endorsed definitions of Combat Mindset, Performance Under Pressure and the Army Combat Mindset Framework, together with the agreed relationship between the three.

Phase 1: Capability and product stocktake (August 2026)

Conduct a stocktake of existing doctrine, content, products, courses, instructor capability, delivery activity, evidence, ownership and assurance arrangements across ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and selected units. The stocktake will distinguish:

- doctrinal and policy holdings;
- capability outcomes;
- training products and methods;
- delivery organisations;
- technical and professional authorities;
- evidence maturity;
- scalability and resource requirements; and
- gaps, duplication and integration opportunities.

The stocktake will identify which products contribute to the broader Performance Under Pressure capability and which support its combat-specific expression. COGCON will be assessed as one developmental product within this stocktake, with particular attention to its product boundary, evidence base — including its completed feasibility trials in live military training — ownership, workforce requirements and scalability.

Phase 2: Framework and product architecture (September 2026)

Draft the Army Combat Mindset Framework as the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure Performance Under Pressure and its combat-specific expression. The framework will include the endorsed definitions and desired operational effect; the integrated capability pillars; developmental outcomes from Lead Self through Lead Systems; the relationship between doctrine, framework, products and delivery; common assurance principles; and the criteria by which existing and future products may be recognised as contributing to the framework.

Existing products, including the NZALC Performance Under Pressure package and COGCON, will be mapped beneath the relevant capability pillars rather than treated as the framework itself.

Phase 3: Stakeholder forum (September 2026)

Convene ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, selected training providers and units to refine the framework, product architecture, governance model, implementation priorities, definition clarity and doctrinal coherence.

Phase 4: Report back (November 2026)

Present the endorsed definitions and the confirmed relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure; Framework v1.0 and its agreed architecture; the validated capability and product map; the proposed governance and assurance model; and a prioritised implementation plan. The report will identify whether COGCON should remain a developmental product; undergo further controlled evaluation; be integrated selectively into existing training; be prepared for broader scaling; or cease or change direction.

5. Governance

The following arrangements are proposed for confirmation at Phase 0. Technical and professional authority is distributed by domain; no single organisation owns the evidence base for the entire capability.

- Army Sponsor — strategic sponsor for Combat Mindset, the enabling Performance Under Pressure capability and the Army Combat Mindset Framework.
- Interim capability integrator — COMDT ACS, coordinating definition, framework development, stakeholder engagement and recommendations to the Army Sponsor.
- Capability development and delivery coordinator — ACS, coordinating the framework, developmental architecture and recognised training products, leveraging NZALC and wider ACS expertise, intellectual property and programmes.
- COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser — Human Performance Cell, responsible for the integrity and further development of the COGCON method and for specialist advice on cognitive conditioning and proportionate measurement, within available capacity.
- Domain advisers and authorities — NZDF Psychology, ILD, physical-performance specialists, doctrine staff and other relevant organisations, providing technical or professional advice within their respective domains.
- Delivery agencies — training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces approved to deliver recognised products.
- Assurance — a layered assurance model covering doctrine, evidence, professional content, learning design, delivery quality and operational relevance, with sufficient independence from individual product owners and delivery organisations.

6. Recommendations

It is recommended that COMDT ACS:

1. **Endorse** the problem statement at paragraph 1.
2. **Endorse** Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure, and Performance Under Pressure as the enabling, trainable individual and collective human-performance capability.
3. **Endorse** the formal definitions at paragraph 2 as the baseline for staffing.
4. **Endorse** the Army Combat Mindset Framework as the organising model through which Army will define, develop, integrate and assure the capabilities, products and governance arrangements that enable Combat Mindset.
5. **Note** that existing programmes and products will be mapped beneath the framework's capability pillars and will not constitute the framework in isolation.
6. **Endorse** COGCON's interim status as a developmental product within the performance-cognition pillar.
7. **Confirm** the governance model at paragraph 5, including COMDT ACS as interim capability integrator pending confirmation of the Army Sponsor, and HPC as COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser.
8. **Approve** the programme of work at paragraph 4, including the capability and product stocktake, framework development and stakeholder engagement.
9. **Direct** that the November 2026 report provide the endorsed definitions and confirmed relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure; Framework v1.0 and its agreed architecture; the validated capability and product map; a governance and assurance model; an assessment of COGCON's evidence, scalability, resource requirements and appropriate future role; and a prioritised implementation plan.

Annex A — Initial capability and product architecture

A1. Doctrinal hierarchy

Hierarchy	Composition
Warfighting imperative	Individuals, teams and leaders remain effective and act decisively, persistently, adaptively and ethically under combat conditions
Combat-specific expression	Combat Mindset
Enabling human-performance capability	Performance Under Pressure
Organising model	Army Combat Mindset Framework
Capability pillars	Leadership; mental skills; performance cognition; resilience and recovery; physical performance; professional identity and values; individual and collective exposure to pressure
Training products and methods	NZALC Performance Under Pressure package; COGCON; NZDF Psychology products; scenario and experiential training; physical conditioning; structured reflection and recovery; other products identified during the Phase 1 stocktake

Warfighting imperative → Combat Mindset → enabled by Performance Under Pressure → developed and organised through the Army Combat Mindset Framework → delivered through capability pillars, products and methods

A2. Division of functions

Function	Lead	Output
Define and govern	Army Sponsor / ACS	Endorsed doctrine, definitions, policy direction and capability outcomes
Integrate capability	ACS	Framework, product architecture, stakeholder coordination and implementation priorities
Develop products	Relevant product owner	Product design, protocols, instructor materials and updates
Provide domain advice	Relevant technical or professional adviser	Specialist advice within leadership, psychology, cognition, learning design, physical performance and other domains
Deliver	Approved training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces	Routine delivery of recognised products
Measure training performance	Delivery organisation, using approved methods	Proportionate training feedback and product-level performance data

UNCLASSIFIED

Function	Lead	Output
Evaluate product effectiveness	Product owner, with independent evaluation or research support	Evidence of feasibility, effectiveness, transfer and scalability
Assure	Layered governance and domain authorities	Doctrine, evidence, professional, learning, delivery and operational assurance
Review and recover	Relevant leadership and training systems	Reflection, feedback, recovery and developmental planning